

Sample Test Strategy

An organisation-level strategy that shapes every project test plan.

Test Plan vs Test Strategy

The syllabus distinguishes the two clearly, and so should you. A test strategy is a high-level, organisation-wide document describing how testing is done across projects. A test plan is project-specific and describes how a particular release will be tested. Individual test plans inherit from, and must not contradict, this strategy.

Test strategy	Test plan
Organisation or programme level	Single project or release
Stable, changes rarely	Created per release, changes often
Sets standards and principles	Applies those standards to real work

1. Purpose

This strategy defines the standard testing approach for all software delivered by Acme Financial Services. Its goal is consistent, risk-appropriate quality across every product and team.

2. Test Levels

Every project applies the same four levels, tailored in depth to the risk of the product.

Level	Owner	Primary objective
Component testing	Developers	Verify units in isolation
Integration testing	Developers and testers	Verify interfaces between components
System testing	Test team	Verify the whole system against requirements
Acceptance testing	Business and users	Confirm fitness for use and readiness for release

3. Test Types

- Functional — behaviour matches the specification.

- Non-functional — performance, security, usability, reliability.
- Structural — coverage of code and architecture where required.
- Change-related — confirmation testing and regression testing after every fix.

4. Risk-Based Approach

All projects prioritise testing by product risk. Higher-risk areas (money movement, authentication, data privacy) receive deeper coverage; lower-risk areas receive lighter, mostly automated checks. Risk is reassessed at each release.

5. Test Automation Policy

- Regression tests are automated and run in continuous integration.
- New features are automated once behaviour is stable.
- Manual effort is reserved for exploratory testing and one-off checks.

6. Environments and Test Data

A dedicated, production-like test environment is maintained for each product. Test data is anonymised where it derives from production, in line with data-protection policy.

7. Standards and Roles

Area	Standard
Defect management	All defects logged in the central tracker with severity and priority
Reporting	Every release produces a test summary report
Independence	System testing is performed by testers independent of the developers

8. Test Process Improvement

Each release closes with a retrospective. Lessons that apply across projects are folded back into this strategy so the whole organisation improves, not just one team.

REMEMBER FOR THE EXAM

A strategy is organisation-wide and long-lived; a plan is project-specific and short-lived. If a question asks which document defines "how the organisation tests in general", the answer is the test strategy.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

When you join a new employer, ask to read their test strategy on day one. It tells you the levels, types, tools and standards you are expected to work within — far faster than picking it up project by project.